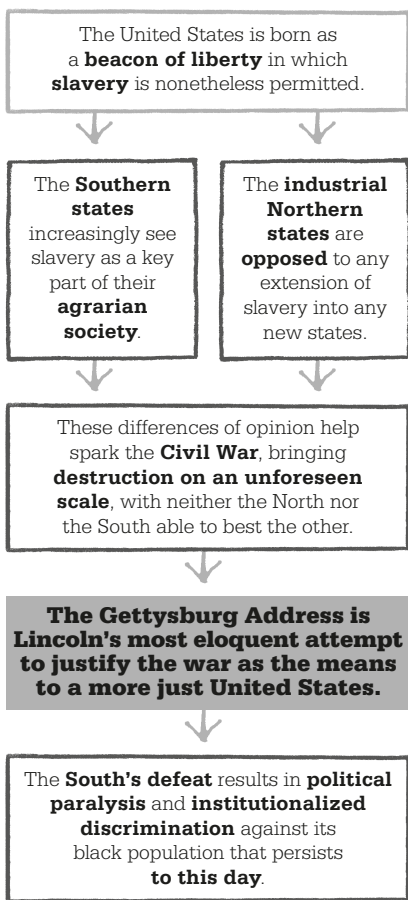




British rule. In the minds of many Southerners, the US government was guilty of precisely the same kind of tyranny in seeking to limit these freedoms.

It was a deeply held position. As Alexander Stephens, vice-president of the Confederacy, asserted, the cornerstone of this new state "rest[ed] upon the great truth that the negro is not equal to the white man; that slavery ... is his natural and normal condition ..."

As a supreme political operator, Lincoln realized the need to proceed with caution. Initially at any rate, his position was that he sought only to restrict the expansion of

slavery while preserving the Union. On the second point, Lincoln was immovable; he felt the authority of the federal government overrode that of individual states.

The United States, the only fully democratic country on Earth, had been created as what Lincoln called "a great promise to the world," so ensuring its survival was an absolute moral duty. By the time of his Emancipation Proclamation in January 1863, Lincoln felt politically secure enough to order the freeing of all enslaved people in the South. But in the short term, the Civil War was fought to keep this "great promise" intact.

Eventual Northern victory

The outcome of the American Civil War was dictated ultimately by the human and material discrepancies between the North and the South. There were 21 Union states with a population of 20 million, and 11 Southern states with a population of 9 million, 4 million of whom were enslaved, and therefore not allowed to bear arms. Despite the fact that by 1864, 44 percent of males in the North aged 18 to 60 were in military service, versus 90 percent in the Southern states, the North was still able to enlist 2.2 million men over the whole war, compared to the South's 800,000.

The North was three times richer than the South. It had 2.4 miles (3.8 km) of railroad to every 1 mile (1.6 km) in the South. Its factories manufactured 10 times more goods. It produced 20 times more iron than the South, 38 times as much coal, and 32 times as many firearms. The only area in which the South exceeded the North was in cotton production, at 24 to 1.

In the face of this superiority, the fact that the South was not only able to resist the Union forces for four years but also to

“I cannot raise my hand against my birthplace, my home, my children.

Robert E. Lee

On his resignation (April 1861)